

EXCEL Entertainment

So you think MS Excel is meant only for work, work and work. Read on and think again!

Microsoft Excel, that powerful spreadsheet Office application that you use to tabulate figures everyday, supports Visual Basic, a popular programming language. Therefore, it can be used to program anything—even games. All you need is Excel 2000 or higher installed on your PC, and your system even need not be a high-end one.

Amuse yourself at work with these games, while you give the impression of doing some serious number crunching to your colleagues! And yes, besides games, Excel has some interesting hidden secrets too. But, first let's get down to gaming.

Warm up

Before you begin, run an anti-virus scan since these games employ macros, and there are chances of macro viruses being embedded in the Excel file.

Secondly, set the security settings in Excel to Medium by going to **Tools > Macros > Security**. This way

you will be asked whether you want to run an unsigned macro or not. While you will need to enable macros for the game files, you can choose to disable macros for files whose source is unknown. Note that some of the games may also require DirectX.

Where do I find them?

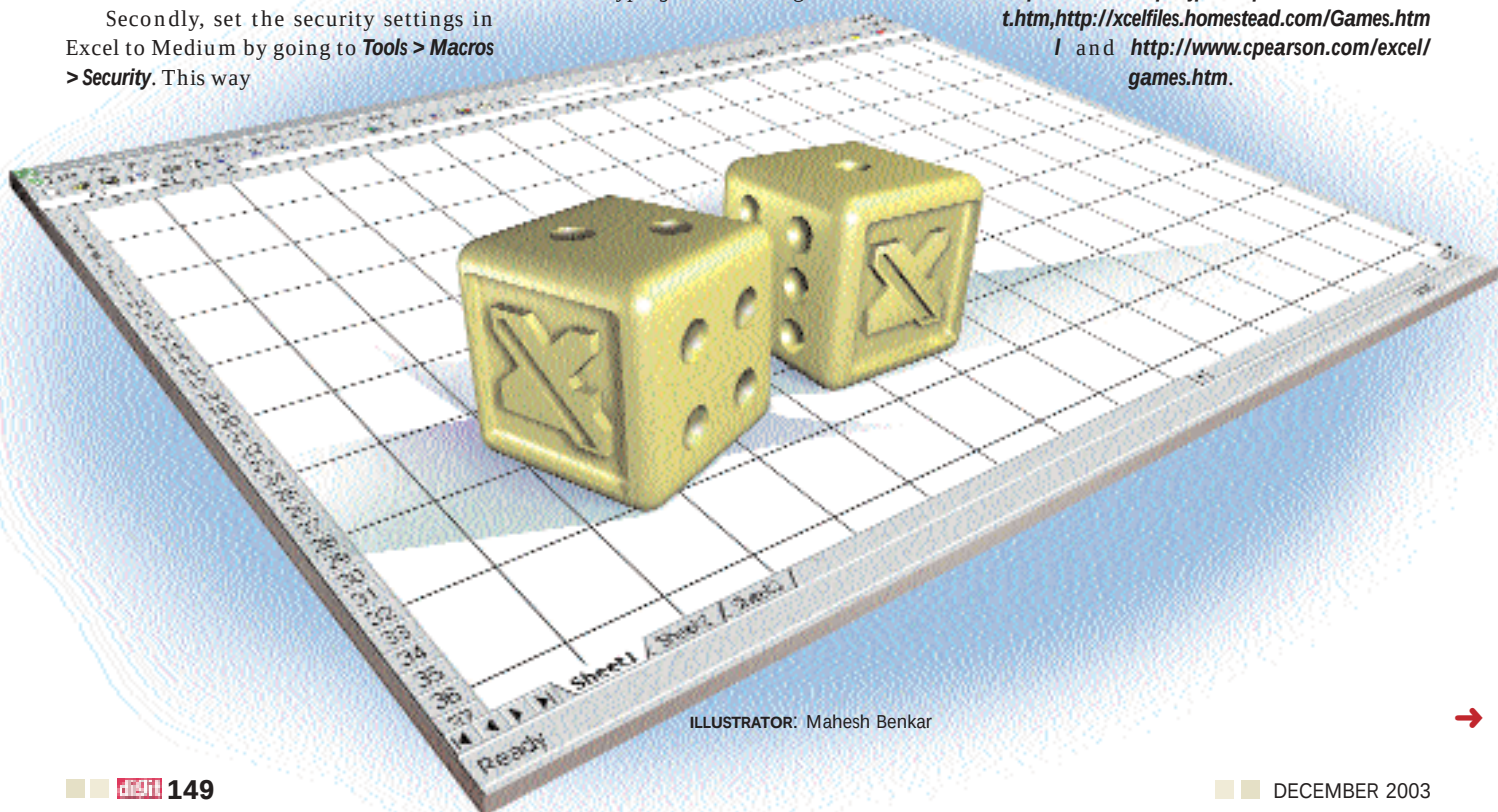
One of the many Web sites that you can look up to find Excel games is www.xl-logic.com/pages/games.html. This site has an impressive collection of around fifty games, collected from various sources—we recommend *Excellon-II*, a vertical scrolling shooting game with good visuals and sounds. Others from the same programmer include *Billiards*, *Cylcotron* and *Excelizer*, as well as *Typing Soccer* and *Typing Runner*—both designed to enhance your typing skills.

In *Typing Soccer*, the ground is divid-

ed into a number of areas, each containing a letter that represents your players. Kicking the ball entails pressing the corresponding key on the keyboard. Similarly, use the appropriate keys in *Typing Runner* to feed the cat that's at one end of the board with the food placed at the other end, and bring it back home.

A site called <http://lazyslug.homeip.net> is where you'll find the Excel version of *Minesweeper*, and other interesting games such as *RobotsXL*. Another Web site—Mr. Excel (www.mrexcel.com)—has a huge collection of free games, thanks to the Excel game contest it ran recently. You can also surf to <http://www.mrexcel.com/pc10.php> and see what interests you—*Snake* enthusiasts will find two versions of this game at this Web site.

Other Web sites worth a visit are <http://www.interq.or.jp/sun/puremis/colo/freesoft.htm>, <http://xcelfiles.homestead.com/Games.htm> and <http://www.cpearson.com/excel/games.htm>.



ILLUSTRATOR: Mahesh Benkar